Every date has an owner. Every slip shows where it lands.

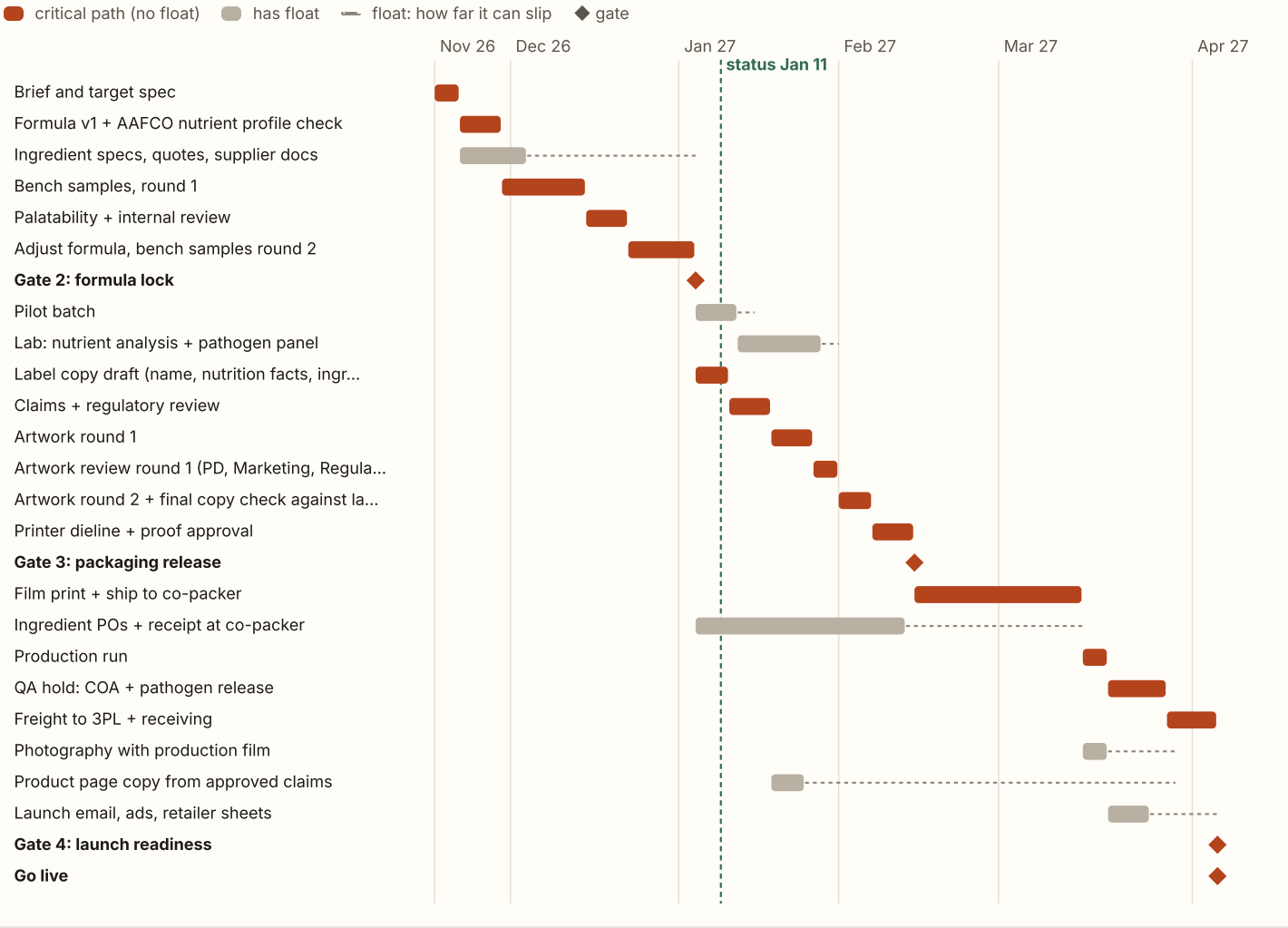
Read this first: one fictional SKU, Brindle & Co. Air-Dried Salmon & Pumpkin, planned from brief to go-live on a working-day calendar. Brand, vendors, durations and costs are illustrative. The schedule calculation is tested. US label notes summarise FDA and AAFCO sources and are not legal advice. The live version lets you tick slips and watch every tab recalculate.

Apr 6, 2027
calculated go-live
93 working days from the brief, holidays excluded

15 of 22
steps on the critical path
after formula lock, packaging sets the date, not formula

+5 → +1 days
impact of a lab retest
before and after decoupling copy from lab results

5
resource conflicts across 4 projects
found before anyone double-books the co-packer



What the plan says

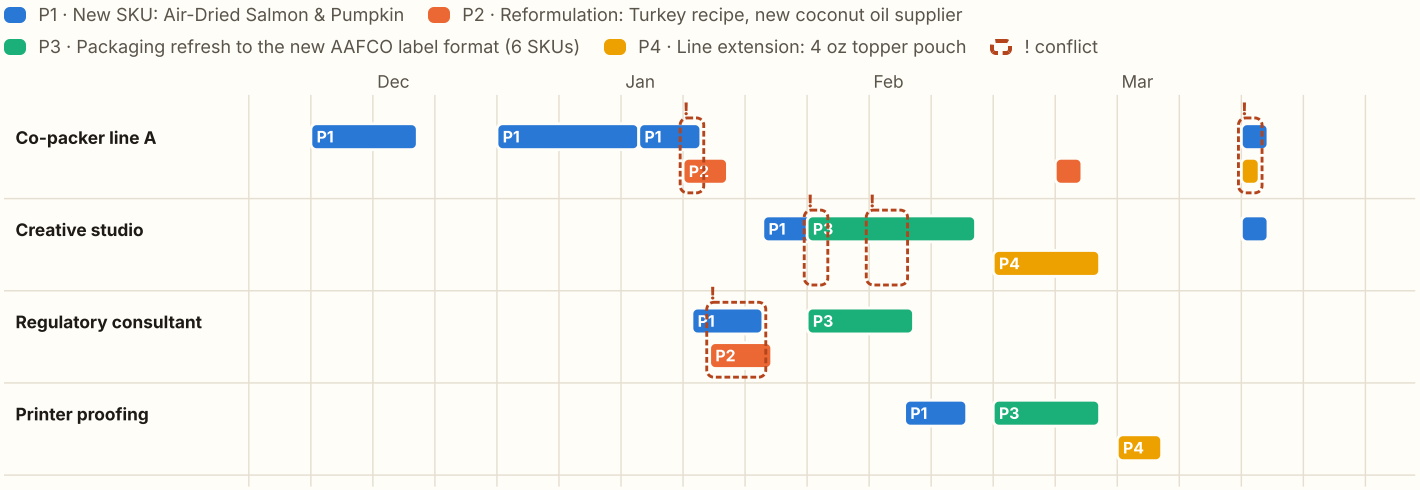
- Packaging, not formula, sets the date after Gate 2: copy, review, two artwork rounds, proof and 20 working days of film.
- Ingredient orders have 21 days of float; chasing them early buys nothing.
- A lab retest costs 5 days only because final copy waits for lab values. Route copy on formulation values and let the lab confirm before the printer proof: the same retest costs 1.
- The film order is the single biggest block: lock bag size and dieline at Gate 2, not after artwork.

What if... (each slip on its own)

Slip	Go-live	Cost
Artwork needs a third round +4 days on artwork round 2	+4 d	$1,000
Pathogen panel needs a retest +7 days on the lab	+5 d	$900
Printer quotes 10 more days for film +10 days on film	+10 d	–
Bench samples need a third round +8 days before formula lock	+8 d	$1,100
Fix: route copy on formulation values; lab confirms before the printer proof	retest +5 → +1	$0

Four projects, one calendar

The launch runs beside a reformulation, a packaging refresh to the new AAFCO label format and a line extension. Conflicts come from the bookings, not from memory.



5 conflicts, with a proposed resolution

Resource	Overlap	Between	Proposed resolution
Co-packer line A	Jan 11 → Jan 12	P1 Pilot batch P2 Bench samples	Slide the launch's "Pilot batch" by 2 working days: it has 2 days of float, so the go-live date holds.
Co-packer line A	Mar 15 → Mar 16	P1 Production run P4 Pouch line trial	The launch's "Production run" is on the critical path. Move P4 "Pouch line trial" to start Mar 18, or agree extra capacity with the co-packer line A.
Creative studio	Jan 25 → Jan 26	P1 Artwork round 1 P3 Artwork, 6 SKUs	The launch's "Artwork round 1" is on the critical path. Move P3 "Artwork, 6 SKUs" to start Jan 27, or agree extra capacity with the creative studio.
Creative studio	Feb 1 → Feb 4	P1 Artwork round 2 + final copy check against lab results P3 Artwork, 6 SKUs	The launch's "Artwork round 2 + final copy check against lab results" is on the critical path. Move P3 "Artwork, 6 SKUs" to start Feb 5, or agree extra capacity with the creative studio.
Regulatory consultant	Jan 14 → Jan 19	P1 Claims + regulatory review P2 Ingredient panel re-review	The launch's "Claims + regulatory review" is on the critical path. Move P2 "Ingredient panel re-review" to start Jan 20, or agree extra capacity with the regulatory consultant.

Resolutions use float from the calculated plan where the launch is involved, and project priority otherwise. They are proposals for the weekly meeting, not decisions.

Stage gates, dated by the plan

G0 Concept approved · before the brief
signs: Head of PD · 3 checks

G1 Feasible · before the brief
signs: Head of PD · 4 checks

G2 Formula locked · Jan 6
signs: Head of PD · 4 checks

G3 Packaging released · Feb 12
signs: Head of PD · 5 checks

G4 Launch ready · Apr 6
signs: Head of PD · 5 checks

Artwork routing: 8 steps, no skipping

1. **Copy deck** · PD project manager
2. **Claims + regulatory review** · Regulatory consultant
3. **Artwork round 1** · Creative
4. **Cross-functional review** · PD, Marketing, Operations
5. **Artwork round 2 + lab check** · Creative + PM
6. **Printer proof** · Printer
7. **Final sign-off** · Approval matrix
8. **Release + archive** · PD project manager

US label and claims gate

- FDA: claims to cure, treat, prevent or mitigate disease can make a product an unapproved new animal drug.
- FDA counts off-pack claims too: a Nov 2024 warning letter cited a company's Facebook and third-party pages.
- Product name checked against AAFCO's 95% / 25% / "with" / "flavor" rules.
- Refreshes built in the new Pet Nutrition Facts format (AAFCO PFLM, approved 31 Jul 2023).

Monday update, generated from the plan (excerpt)

```
GO-LIVE: Tue, Apr 6, 2027 (on baseline)
BUDGET: $2,200 spent of $18,000; $2,500 contingency untouched

DECISIONS NEEDED
  ? Co-packer line A, Jan 11-Jan 12: P1 vs P2. Slide the launch's "Pilot batch" by 2 working days: it has 2 days of float, so the
go-live date holds.
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Sources: FDA, Animal Food Labeling and Pet Food Claims · FDA warning letter, 12 Nov 2024 · AAFCO, Pet Food Label Modernization · Virginia Tech FST-434